



POI Solla POROM

Produced by Priyadarshan, a Tamil remake of the Hindi sleeper comic hit, *Khosla ka Ghosla*.

It's not the same in Bollywood." Add to that the opening up of the diaspora for Tamil films (in Malaysia, Singapore and Sri Lanka) and it's no wonder that Bollywood is seeking southern comfort.

This sudden bonding is also being bolstered by a handful of individuals. There's Priyadarshan, who is producing *Poi Solla Porom*, a remake of *Khosla ka Ghosla* (yes, sometimes even Bollywood can become a source of stories) in Tamil. And having decided to do Hindi films for money and southern films for love and artistic satisfaction, as he prepares to start *Dhan Dhan Dhan* with Akshay, Sunil Shetty and Paresh Rawal, Priyadarshan is quite excited about his Tamil film *Kanjivaram* that has been selected for the Toronto Film Festival. "In Mumbai, no one wants me to deviate from the formula, but in the south, I can experiment," he says.

Not everyone is happy with this state of affairs. Director S. Ramanarayanan, also president of the Tamil Film Producers' Council, has said the entry of the Mumbai corporate world has inflated star salaries down the line, beyond the reach of southern majors. But lower costs and greater transparency are among the major factors attracting them. With even newcomers like Ranbir Kapoor and Imraan Khan being paid in the vicinity of Rs 6 crore, established actors like Babu (who don't get more than Rs 1 crore) seem like bargains.

With Bollywood discovering that the script is the king, apart from the obvious *badshahs* and *shehenshahs*, corporates are sold on the scripts. In any case, says UTV's Ram Mirchandani, the best stories have always been told in Tamil cinema. UTV's got *Kannamoochi Enada*, directed by Mani Ratnam's chief assistant Priya V., and the bilingual *Lost in Chennai*, directed by Anand Subramaniam. Reliance is a 50 per cent partner in Soundarya Rajnikant's animation film, *Sultan: The Warrior*. It is also bankrolling Shaji N. Karun, M.S. Sathyu and



KANJIVARAM

Art house Tamil film, directed by Priyadarshan, starring Prakash Raj, produced by Percept.

trained technicians. Take the case of *Ghajini*. Not only is it being directed by A. Murugadoss who helmed the original, but even the main crew is from Chennai—from Ravi K. Chandran who's behind the camera to Peter Hein who is masterminding the action. It's a way of working that appeals to those who believe in quick results. Says Jayanth Paranjy, who directed the Telugu remake of *Munna Bhai MBBS*, "If you're working with a superstar like Chiranjeevi, a 7 a.m. call means he will be ready, with make-up, by 6.45 a.m.



AEGAN

Tamil action film starring Ajith and Nayantara, produced by Ayngaran and Eros.

Mani Ratnam's new films, while signing on Chiranjeevi for a sequel to *Autograph*. "A market exists everywhere and we aim to be a national leader in the movie space as well," says Khanna. Because what the southern industry lacks in size (a Hindi blockbuster now releases across more than 1,800 screens whereas even *Sivaji: The Boss* got only 600 screens worldwide), it makes up for in sheer originality. It's a relationship that looks like it will last, even if neither actually learns to speak the other's language. ■